

ILO Complaint by Tea Workers



Source: TH

The Paschim Banga Cha Majoor Samity (a non-political trade union) filed a formal representation with the **International Labour Organization (ILO)** under **Article 24 of the ILO Constitution**, citing systemic **state failure** in protecting basic labor rights.

- The complaint alleges the Indian government has failed to uphold ratified Conventions regarding **forced labor**, **equal remuneration**, **non-discrimination**, and the rights of indigenous and tribal populations, among others.

Article 24 of ILO

- **About:** Article 24 of the ILO Constitution is a key procedural mechanism that allows for the **monitoring** and **enforcement** of international labor standards.
- **Function:** Under Article 24, any **industrial association of employers or of workers** (such as a trade union or an employers' federation) has the right to make a "representation" to the ILO's International Labour Office.
- **Eligibility for Filing a Representation:** Eligibility for filing a representation is restricted exclusively to industrial associations, such as **trade unions or employer organizations**; individual citizens and **NGOs** lacking this specific status are ineligible.
- **Scope:** It applies only to **ratified Conventions** and alleges failure to ensure their effective observance within the member state's jurisdiction.
 - **India** has ratified **6** out of the **10** core/fundamental ILO Conventions. These include the **Abolition of Forced Labour Convention, 1957 (No. 105)**, Equal Remuneration Convention, 1951 (No. 100), and **Worst Forms of Child Labour Convention, 1999 (No. 182)**, among others.

Ten Core Conventions of the International Labour Organization

(also called fundamental/human rights conventions)

✓ Ratified by India

1. Forced Labour Convention (No. 29)
2. Abolition of Forced Labour Convention (No.105)
3. Equal Remuneration Convention (No.100)
4. Discrimination (Employment Occupation) Convention (No.111)
5. Minimum Age Convention (No.138)
6. Worst forms of Child Labour Convention (No.182)

✗ Not Ratified by India

7. Freedom of Association and Protection of Right to Organised Convention (No.87)
8. Right to Organise and Collective Bargaining Convention (No.98)
9. C155 - Occupational Safety and Health Convention, 1981 (No. 155)
10. C187 - Promotional Framework for Occupational Safety and Health Convention, 2006 (No. 187)

- **Procedure:** The Governing Body may **forward** the representation to the government concerned and **request a response** . If the response is " **not satisfactory** ," **Article 25** of the ILO Constitution grants the power to **publish the representation** and the government's **response** .
- **Purpose:** While the ILO does **not** have the power to **impose economic sanctions** , the " **naming and shaming** " aspect—combined with formal recommendations for legal or policy changes—exerts significant moral and diplomatic pressure on the state to comply with labor standards.



Read More: [International Labour Organization](#)

Cabinet Clears Bill to Expand SC Strength to 38



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Union Cabinet has approved the **Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026**, to increase the sanctioned strength of the **Supreme Court** from **34 to 38** (including the **Chief Justice of India**).

- This change will be enacted by amending the **Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Act, 1956** , ending a six-year hiatus since the last revision in **2019** .
- The expansion is in response to a backlog of **92,385 cases** , further complicated by the post-pandemic surge in digital **e-filings** .

What is the Process to Increase the Sanctioned Strength of the Supreme Court?

- **Constitutional Foundation:** Under **Article 124(1)** of the Indian Constitution, the Supreme Court originally consisted of a **Chief Justice and 7 other judges** . However, the Constitution explicitly gives **Parliament** the power to increase this number by law.
 - Unlike the **High Courts** , where the **President** can increase the number of judges (under **Article 216**

) through executive orders based on workload, the Supreme Court's sanctioned strength can **only be changed through an Act of Parliament** .

- **Legislative Process:** To increase the strength, the following steps are typically followed:
 - **Initiation by CJI:** Usually, the Chief Justice of India (CJI) sends a **proposal** to the **Union Ministry of Law and Justice** , citing reasons like a rising backlog of cases or the need for more Constitution Benches.
 - **Cabinet Approval:** The Law Ministry, after consulting with the **Finance Ministry** (for budgetary implications), places a draft bill before the Union Cabinet.
 - **Introduction of Amendment Bill:** Once the Cabinet approves, the government introduces the **Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill** in Parliament.
 - **Parliamentary Approval:** The bill must be passed by both the **Lok Sabha** and the **Rajya Sabha** by a **simple majority** .
 - **Presidential Assent:** Once passed by both Houses, the bill is sent for the **President's assent** ; upon receiving it, the bill becomes an **Act**, and the sanctioned strength is **officially increased** .
- **Implementation:** The President (on the advice of the **Collegium**) can then appoint additional judges up to the **new sanctioned strength** .
- **Evolutionary Trend:** From an original constitutional strength of **1+7 judges** , the court has expanded progressively (e.g., to 10 in 1956, 13 in 1960, 17 in 1977, and 25 in 1986) to match India's growing legal needs.

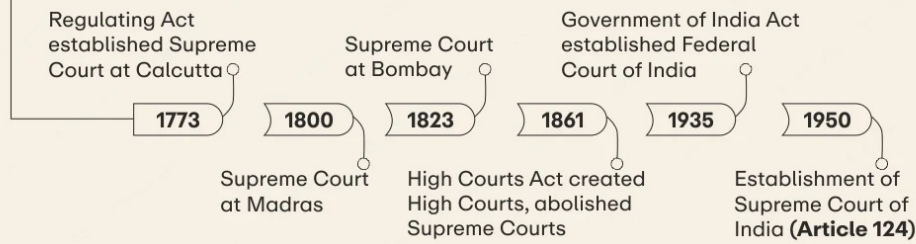
Concerns

- **Systematic Issues: The Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026, overlooks** systemic issues like the **appointment process, listing practices, and heavy Special Leave Petitions (SLP) volumes**. Faster case disposal depends entirely on the **Collegium** and Union's speed in filling seats, as historical expansions have consistently been marred by **persistent judicial vacancies** .
- **Law Commission Recommendation:** The present Bill overlooks the recommendations made by the **18th Law Commission** (chaired by Justice A.R. Lakshmanan) in its **229th Report in 2009** , which proposed that simply adding more judges would not resolve the issues of pendency or access to justice.
 - Instead, the Commission recommended establishing a **Constitution Bench** in Delhi and four regional cassation benches in cities like Chennai, Hyderabad, Kolkata, and Mumbai to handle appellate matters from the High Courts.
- **National Court of Appeal:** The Bill fails to address the ongoing concerns raised by a writ petition filed in 2016, which seeks the establishment of a **National Court of Appeal**, highlighting the need for a more accessible and efficient judicial structure.

SUPREME COURT OF INDIA

The Supreme Court of India is the apex judicial body under the Constitution of India.

HISTORY



COMPOSITION

- ④ **Strength:** 34 judges including CJI, appointed by the President
- ④ **Eligibility:** Indian Citizen; High Court judge for 5 years/Advocate for 10 years/Distinguished jurist
- ④ **Tenure:** Until age 65 (unless resigns/impeached by President)
- ④ **Salaries:** Determined by Parliament
- ④ **Impeachment:** By President on Parliament's approval with a special majority

JURISDICTION

Original, Writ, Appellate and Advisory Jurisdictions:

- ④ **Original:** Disputes between Government and States (Article 131); Constitutional Remedies (Article 32)
- ④ **Writ:** Powers to issue writs for enforcement of fundamental rights (Article 139)
- ④ **Appeals From HCs:**
 - ④ Constitutional Matters (Article 132)
 - ④ Civil Matters (Article 133)
 - ④ Criminal Matters (Article 134)
 - ④ Special Leave (Article 136; Discretionary Power)
- ④ **Advisory:** Presidential referrals (Article 143)

OTHER POWERS

Court of Record, Judicial Review, Constitutional Interpretation etc.

- ④ **Articles 129:** Powers to punish for contempt
- ④ **Article 137:** Supreme Court review of its judgments
- ④ **Article 141:** Supreme Court's decisions are binding on all courts
- ④ **Article 142:** Orders and decrees of the Supreme Court are enforceable
- ④ **Article 147:** SC is the ultimate interpreter of the Constitution

Acting Chief Justice, Ad Hoc Judge, & Retired Judge of SC

- **Acting Chief Justice:** Appointed by the President as needed
- **Ad Hoc Judge:** Appointed temporarily by the CJI for quorum issues
- **Retired Judge:** Chief Justice can reappoint retired judges temporarily



Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the original sanctioned strength of the Supreme Court?

Originally, Article 124(1) of the Constitution envisaged a Supreme Court consisting of a Chief Justice of India and not more than seven other judges, unless Parliament prescribed a larger number by law.

2. Which constitutional provision empowers the expansion of the Supreme Court?

Article 124(1) authorizes Parliament to increase the number of judges by law; without such legislation, the strength remains at the previously prescribed limit.

3. What is the legal requirement for passing the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill?

The Bill must be passed by both Houses of Parliament—the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha—by a simple majority before receiving Presidential Assent.

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Q. With reference to the Indian judiciary, consider the following statements: (2021)

1. Any retired judge of the Supreme Court of India can be called back to sit and act as a Supreme Court judge by the Chief Justice of India with the prior permission of the President of India.
2. A High Court in India has the power to review its own judgement as the Supreme Court does.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (c)

Q. Consider the following statements: (2019)

1. The 44th Amendment to the Constitution of India introduced an Article placing the election of the Prime Minister beyond judicial review.
2. The Supreme Court of India struck down the 99th Amendment to the Constitution of India as being violative of the independence of judiciary.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (b)

Q. With reference to the Constitution of India, consider the following statements: (2019)

1. No High Court shall have the jurisdiction to declare any central law to be constitutionally invalid.
2. An amendment to the Constitution of India cannot be called into question by the Supreme Court of India.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (d)

Metamaterials



Source: TH

Researchers from Europe, in a study published in Nature Physics, have developed **synthetic metamaterials** capable of physically “learning” and changing shape based on external conditions, marking a major breakthrough in adaptive materials and soft robotics.

- **Metamaterials** : They are specially engineered materials whose properties are determined mainly by their physical structure rather than only their chemical composition.
 - Unlike conventional materials, they can exhibit unusual mechanical and physical behaviours not naturally found in ordinary substances.
- **Learning Process**: The metamaterial uses a **hardware-based contrastive learning mechanism**, where each unit compares different physical states and gradually adjusts itself to achieve a target shape.
 - Through repeated environmental feedback, the material can dynamically adjust its bending behaviour to learn, forget, and relearn new shapes.
- **Non-Reciprocity** : The metamaterial exhibits **non-reciprocal behaviour**, meaning it can respond differently depending on the direction of the input.
 - For instance, nudging the material from one side results in a different bending behaviour compared to nudging it from the other side. This allows the material to **learn different ways to attain a final shape without requiring separate training**.
- **Bistable Units**: **The metamaterial contains bistable units that can remain in two stable configurations, enabling it to switch, store, and relearn shapes with minimal energy use.**
- **Potential Applications**: The technology has promising applications in soft robotics, adaptive prosthetic limbs, intelligent responsive materials, and distributed robotic systems that can autonomously adapt to changing environments.

Limitations : Despite its breakthrough potential, the system currently relies on large hardware components and specialized laboratory setups, limiting immediate real-world deployment and scalability.

Read more: [Mantis Shrimp and Metamaterials](#)

Insulting Vande Mataram is a Punishable Offence



Source:TH

The Union Cabinet has recently cleared a proposal to amend **the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971** , making any intentional insult or obstruction to the singing of the National Song, **Vande Mataram** , a legally punishable offence.

- **Current Legal Framework: The Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971** strictly penalizes insults or disrespect towards the **National Anthem (Jana Gana Mana)** , the **National Flag** , and the **Constitution of India** .
- **Proposed Penalties:** Under the existing **Section 3 of the 1971 Act** , intentionally preventing the singing of the **National Anthem** or causing a disturbance carries a punishment of **imprisonment extending up to three years, a fine, or both** .
 - The amendment will extend this **exact statutory protection to the National Song**.
- **MHA Directives:** In February 2026, the **Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA)** issued instructions mandating that all **six stanzas of Vande Mataram** (lasting over three minutes) must be sung or played at official events.
 - The MHA directed that the **National Song should be given precedence over the National Anthem** (written by **Rabindranath Tagore**) when both are featured at the same official event.
 - The Supreme Court held that the MHA guidelines on Vande Mataram are purely advisory and carry **no penal consequences for non-compliance**.
- **Historical Context:** Vande Mataram, conceptualizing India as a mother goddess, was written by **Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay** and published in his highly influential Bengali novel **Anandamath** in the early 1880s.
 - In **1937** , leaders of the **Indian National Congress (INC)** decided to use only the first two stanzas of the song at their gatherings.
 - Following independence, the modern Republic of India officially accorded it the status of the **National Song** , giving it equal historical and cultural footing with the **National Anthem**.

Read more: [150th Anniversary of India's National Song "Vande Mataram"](#)

RBI's UDGAM Portal



Source: TH

The **Supreme Court** is reviewing the operation of the UDGAM portal in response to a **Public Interest Litigation (PIL)** highlighting concerns about dormant funds being transferred to government-managed pools and the challenges heirs face in accessing them.

- **About:** The UDGAM (Unclaimed Deposits – Gateway to Access Information) portal, launched by the **Reserve Bank of India (RBI)**, allows users to **identify unclaimed deposits/accounts across multiple banks**, enabling them to claim the deposits or reactivate their accounts.
 - While the portal facilitates identifying unclaimed deposits, it does not handle claim settlements; claimants must contact the respective banks directly for claim processing.
- **Integration:** The portal **integrates 30 banks that account for nearly 90% of the funds** in the **Depositors' Education and Awareness Fund (DEAF)**, with over 20 lakh users and 44 lakh searches conducted by 1st April 2026.
- **Features:** Since its August 2023 launch, several enhancements have been introduced, including **optional user registration, an improved search interface** with address-based queries, and relaxed restrictions on logins and searches.
- **Challenges:**
 - **Lack of Integration for Various Assets:** It does not include post office deposits, provident funds, and insurance schemes, making it difficult for legal heirs to access all unclaimed assets.
 - **Unawareness of Unclaimed Funds:** Unclaimed funds often remain inaccessible because legal heirs are unaware of them, or banks fail to inform heirs about dormant accounts.
 - **Complicated Claims Process:** The process of claiming unclaimed funds is complicated, especially when there is a clear and undisputed will, as banks require legal documents like succession certificates or probate.

Read More: RBI Guidelines on Inoperative Accounts and Unclaimed Deposits